

# Too Many Cooks

How to lead when everyone is in charge

A CASE STUDY

When an organization is top-heavy with leaders, the resulting problems often look personal. One person seems territorial. Another keeps reopening decisions. An employee starts working around the people who are formally in charge. A manager becomes more controlling. From inside the conflict, each reaction can look like a personality flaw. In my experience, it was often a predictable response to a structure that gave several people overlapping claims on the same work.

That is what I mean by too many cooks.

The people involved did not have equal authority. A manager could make formal decisions. A team lead controlled daily work. A specialist held knowledge nobody else had. An informal leader had the team's trust. An ambitious employee could build enough support to change what actually happened. The org chart showed the reporting lines, but it did not show the whole system.

This kind of shared leadership can work well. Decisions stay close to the work, expertise travels, and managers do not become bottlenecks. The trouble begins when nobody has defined the boundaries. People then have to negotiate who is in charge while trying to do the job. Side conversations begin carrying operational weight. Influence becomes an unofficial veto. One person remains accountable for an outcome while someone else controls whether it happens.

I made some of those character judgments myself. I saw defiance, insecurity, politics, and poor communication. Some of those descriptions were fair. None of them explained why the same conflicts kept returning. I could not understand the people clearly until I also looked at the structure around them.

## The problem beneath “everyone is in charge”

| Source of power     | What it controls                    | Shadow form when boundaries fail           |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Formal authority    | Decisions, performance, resources   | Gatekeeping or title-based control         |
| Operational control | Workflow and implementation         | An unofficial veto over execution          |
| Expertise           | Technical judgment and credibility  | Decisions no one can challenge or audit    |
| Social influence    | Trust and collective interpretation | Coalition-building or false consensus      |
| Access              | Information and senior stakeholders | Selective routing and political escalation |
| Process ownership   | Tools, policies, and approvals      | Territory defended for its own sake        |

No team should try to eliminate these forms of power. It should give each one a legitimate place to operate and a boundary that keeps it connected to responsibility.

Teams must provide legitimate places for four forms of organizational energy:

Authority needs boundaries. Dissent needs safety. Ambition needs pathways. Influence needs responsibility.

When those conditions are absent, shadow versions emerge:

| Missing condition | Shadow behavior                                                   |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clear authority   | Turf wars, paralysis, escalation, and competing chains of command |
| Safe dissent      | Backchanneling, passive resistance, and performative agreement    |

| Missing condition     | Shadow behavior                                                  |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Legitimate ambition   | Territorial expansion, status competition, and unilateral action |
| Responsible influence | Coalition-building, information control, and shadow management   |

A related design failure cuts across all four: accountability without decision rights produces advocacy without resolution-and eventually makes the advocate feel both responsible and superfluous. This is one of the most common consequences of a system in which everyone is involved but no one is clearly sovereign.

The goal is not to create a team without politics or to put every decision back in the manager's hands. It is to make distributed power legible: who decides, how disagreement enters, where ambition can grow, and what responsibility accompanies influence. People should not need shadow politics to get useful work done.

# How I Ended Up Here

I did not set out to write a general theory of leadership. I kept finding myself inside teams with more leaders than clearly separated areas of authority.

In one role, I was a relatively new manager trying to establish ownership of knowledge management and support content while working alongside several other managers and team leads. At the same time, I was managing a talented, ambitious employee who was trying to establish influence of his own. I experienced some of his behavior as defiance and circumvention. Looking back, I can also see that we were both trying to create legitimate territory inside a system that had not made either person's boundaries especially clear.

Years later, I encountered the same structural problem from another position. I was expected to bring perspective, challenge decisions, and champion improvements, but my immediate manager and two team-lead equivalents retained much of the formal and operational authority. I often felt superfluous: important enough to consult, but not attached to a stable area I could clearly own.

Those experiences changed how I understand workplace conflict. Unclear authority does not remain an abstract design problem. It enters relationships. It changes how ordinary disagreement feels. It can make an ambitious employee seem threatening, make a manager hold on more tightly, and make an experienced advisor wonder why the organization created their role at all.

The question connecting those experiences was not simply, "Who is the manager?" It was, "What happens when several people can plausibly act as though they are in charge?" This book is my attempt to answer that question through situations I lived, mistakes I made, and frameworks that helped me understand both.

I am not an organizational leadership expert, and I did not handle every moment well.

The useful lessons arrived later and out of order. I use organizational frameworks here because they gave me language for experiences I could not explain at the time. The stories are mine; the patterns are common. My hope is that managers, team leads, senior individual contributors, and people in leadership-adjacent roles can recognize those patterns earlier than I did.

The case studies are anonymized and focus on the organizational dynamics rather than the identities of the people involved.

# **1. Start with the Structure, Not the Personality**

My first instinct was to compete with the person. As a newer manager, I felt my authority was being challenged, so I responded by trying to secure it.

I now begin by diagnosing the organizational structure. That does not remove individual accountability, including my own, but it changes the order in which I ask questions.

Before deciding that a member of the team is oppositional, ask whether the organization has clear answers to the following questions:

- Who owns the problem?
- Who makes the decision?
- Whose input is required?
- Who executes the decision?
- What can individuals decide independently?
- How can a decision be challenged?
- What opportunities exist for greater scope?
- What happens when no promotion path exists?
- Does accountability match the authority and resources provided?

A team may have a clear org chart and still have contested authority. Titles describe reporting relationships; they do not necessarily describe how decisions are made.

Consider a support department with two team leads, a manager, a director, and several senior specialists. If a frontline employee could plausibly take the same question to three different people and receive three different answers, authority has not been distributed. It has been diffused.

Common symptoms include:

- Decisions repeatedly reopening after they were supposedly settled.
- Meetings attended by everyone “just in case.”
- Leaders checking with one another before making routine calls.
- Employees shopping for the answer they prefer.
- Senior ICs acting because waiting for approval seems pointless.
- Leaders protecting processes as proxies for protecting their roles.
- Important information moving through relationships rather than defined channels.
- Responsibility becoming difficult to assign when something fails.
- People being asked to “drive” outcomes they cannot decide, resource, or enforce.

## Structure and personality interact

A flawed system does not produce identical behavior in everyone. Place ten talented people inside the same ambiguous structure and one may disengage, one may leave, one may ask directly for more scope, one may become an excellent informal lieutenant, and one may build a competing center of power.

Structure creates incentives and opportunities. Personality, skill, history, and judgment influence the response.

A rigorous diagnosis therefore holds three propositions at once:

- The structure may be enabling the conflict.
- The manager may be reinforcing it.
- The employee may still be choosing unacceptable behavior.

The practical question is not, “Who is the villain?” It is:

What combination of system design, leadership behavior, and individual conduct is producing this pattern-and which parts can I change?

## 2. Decide Who Actually Decides

I spent too much energy trying to make my authority feel secure. What would have helped more was making its boundaries clear. Authority is more durable when people can see where it begins and ends than when a manager has to defend it in every disagreement.

A useful authority map distinguishes at least four roles:

- Owner: accountable for the result and for maintaining the system.
- Decider: makes the final call on a particular decision.
- Contributor: provides expertise or affected-party input.
- Executor: carries out the decision within agreed guardrails.

One person may occupy several roles, but the roles should not be left implicit.

### Example: knowledge management

| Area                       | Owner           | Decision rights                               | Required input             | Escalation trigger                     |
|----------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Overall content strategy   | Support manager | Sets priorities and standards                 | Team leads and content SME | Major policy or budget change          |
| Returns content            | Senior IC       | Creates and revises articles within standards | Returns specialists        | Change affects company policy          |
| QA standards               | Team lead       | Sets scoring method                           | Managers and agents        | Material staffing or compliance impact |
| Individual case resolution | Frontline agent | Decides within service guardrails             | SME when needed            | Cost or risk exceeds threshold         |

This prevents two common failures: giving someone responsibility for an outcome without enough authority to influence it, and allowing someone to exercise authority without making them accountable for the result.

Language that clarifies decision rights

|                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “I want your recommendation, but I own the final decision.”                                                                                  |
|                                                                                                                                              |
| “This decision is yours. You do not need my approval unless one of these conditions applies.”                                                |
|                                                                                                                                              |
| “We share an interest in this area, but we do not share the same decision rights. Let’s document where your authority ends and mine begins.” |
|                                                                                                                                              |
| “You own the project. I remain accountable for the broader system, so these three decisions need to come back to me.”                        |

Warning sign: ownership without borders

“Take the lead on this” is often presented as empowerment, but it is dangerously vague. Does the person have permission to assign work, change policy, speak for the team, commit resources, or reject competing requests?

Every meaningful delegation should specify:

- The desired outcome.
- The decisions being delegated.
- The decisions being retained.
- The relevant constraints.
- The resources available.
- The people who must be consulted.
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- The review point.
- The measures of success.

This gives people territory without requiring them to conquer it.

## 3. Responsibility without ownership

I later experienced the same structural problem from the other side. I had a role that sounded important in conversation but often felt unnecessary in operation. Overlapping authority does not always create an obvious power struggle; sometimes it creates a person who is expected to influence everything and empowered to own almost nothing.

A person in this position may be expected to bring perspective, identify risks, challenge assumptions, champion initiatives, build alignment, and influence operational owners. Yet the same person may lack stable authority to make the relevant decision, set priorities, assign resources, change the process, hold others accountable, or implement the position they have been asked to champion.

This creates a structural mismatch: the person is held responsible for influence without being given stable ownership.

Their judgment is important enough to solicit, but it is not attached to a clearly defined domain in which they can act. Their contribution therefore depends on persuading people who possess the operational authority they lack.

### The hidden labor of ambiguous influence

In a well-designed role, authority is established before the work begins. In an ambiguous influence role, authority must be renegotiated during the work.

Every issue can become a second argument about jurisdiction:

- Is this mine to decide or merely mine to comment on?
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- Am I advising the manager or directing the work?
- Does the team lead need to follow my recommendation?
- If we disagree, whose position governs?
- Am I accountable for an outcome I cannot control?
- If my perspective is rejected, what function does my role serve?

This produces a distinctive exhaustion. The person does not simply perform the work; they must continually establish why their judgment should matter and persuade someone else to activate it.

Success may also be difficult to recognize because it appears as another person making the decision, assigning the resources, or implementing the idea. The contribution is real, but its connection to the result is indirect. Over time, the person may feel simultaneously important and unnecessary.

## When leadership layers become redundant

This problem commonly appears when several roles occupy the same leadership space:

- An immediate manager retains formal authority.
- Team-lead equivalents control daily operations and hold trusted relationships with the team.
- A leadership-adjacent specialist or program owner is expected to shape direction across the same area.

All three may have legitimate reasons to participate. The problem is that their different forms of authority have not been separated.

The manager may control performance, resources, and final approval. The team leads may control workflow and possess the strongest informal influence. The specialist may be expected to supply strategy or expert

judgment. Without explicit boundaries, the specialist becomes an additional leadership layer without a distinct mechanism of action.

The organization has added another voice without redistributing the machinery of decision-making.

## Why the problem becomes personal

People in ambiguous influence roles are often told to improve stakeholder management, build credibility, or become more persuasive. Those skills matter, but they cannot permanently compensate for defective role design.

When every outcome depends on persuasion, ordinary disagreement can begin to feel like a referendum on whether the role should exist. The person may become increasingly forceful because influence must be repeatedly won rather than exercised through established authority. Others may experience that force as territoriality, unnecessary argument, or an attempt to control work the person does not formally own.

The conflict can then be misdiagnosed as a personality problem: “They need too much control,” “They are not collaborative,” or “They always have to win.” Sometimes those descriptions are accurate. But the structural question must come first:

Has this person been given an outcome to own, or merely an expectation that they somehow cause other owners to produce it?

A role cannot be repaired solely by asking its occupant to tolerate ambiguity when the ambiguity concerns the basic relationship among judgment, responsibility, and action.

## Advisory authority versus decision authority

Influence roles can work when their advisory nature is explicit.

For example:

“You own the analysis and recommendation. The operations manager owns the decision. If the decision differs from your recommendation, the manager accepts accountability for the outcome.”

This is structurally different from:

“You are responsible for improving the process, but the manager and team leads decide whether any recommendation is adopted.”

The first gives the advisor a defined product, a recognized place in the decision, and protection against being held accountable for someone else's choice. The second creates responsibility without control.

A viable advisory role should specify:

- The decision to which the advice contributes.
- The advisor's exclusive area of ownership.
- Who makes the final decision.
- How disagreement is resolved.
- Whether the decision-maker must formally respond.
- Who is accountable when the recommendation is not followed.
- How the advisor's contribution will be evaluated.
- Which decisions the advisor can make independently.

## A role-clarification script

“I’m expected to bring a cross-functional perspective and champion improvements. The boundary between my role, my manager’s role, and the team leads’ roles is unclear. I’d like us to identify the decisions I make, the decisions I advise on, the outcomes I own, and what happens when the relevant leaders disagree. That would help me focus my effort and avoid duplicating or competing with other leadership roles.”

If the organization cannot provide those answers, the ambiguity is not merely an interpersonal misunderstanding. It is part of the job’s design.

## Case study: important enough to consult, unable to decide

A leadership-adjacent employee worked alongside an immediate manager and two team-lead equivalents. The employee was expected to offer perspective, argue for improvements, and champion particular priorities. The manager retained formal authority, while the team leads held substantial operational influence and day-to-day access to the team.

No one had clearly separated advisory responsibility from decision authority. The employee could identify problems and advocate for solutions but could not reliably decide, resource, or implement them. Success depended on persuading one of the other leaders to activate the recommendation.

The employee often felt superfluous. That feeling was not simply a need for more control. The role had no stable relationship among judgment, responsibility, and action. Because persuasion was the principal instrument available, disagreement became a large share of the work and could easily be mistaken for a personality problem.

The corrective questions would have been:

- Which decisions belong exclusively to the employee?

- Which decisions require the employee's recommendation but belong to the manager?
- What do the team leads control?
- Who resolves disagreement among the four roles?
- How is the employee evaluated when someone else rejects the recommendation?
- What result can the employee point to as unambiguously theirs?

The case illustrates a recurring principle: adding a perspective is not the same as designing a role.

## SECTION 4

# 4. Make Dissent Part of the Process

I used to think that telling people they could disagree was enough. It was not. People also needed to know where disagreement belonged, who would decide, and what everyone was expected to do after the decision.

Use:

Challenge -> Discuss -> Decide -> Commit -> Revisit with evidence

## Challenge

People may question assumptions, identify risks, offer alternatives, and disagree with authority.

## Discuss

The owner creates enough room for the strongest relevant arguments to be heard. This is not a promise of unlimited debate or consensus.

## Decide

The designated decision-maker makes the call and explains the reasoning, especially the tradeoffs.

## Commit

Once decided, participants implement the decision in good faith even if their preferred option lost.

## Revisit with evidence

The decision may be reopened when new facts, measurable results, or materially changed conditions justify it. Persistent dislike alone is not new evidence.

## Team norm

“I expect you to challenge decisions you believe are wrong. Bring the evidence, risks, and alternatives. Once the decision is made, we execute it together unless new information materially changes the situation.”

Managers must model this upward. A manager who publicly disowns every decision made above them teaches the team that commitment is optional whenever authority feels illegitimate.

## 5. The Four Horsemen of Backchanneling

A private channel is not automatically a governance problem. The relevant question is not whether people are talking outside the manager's presence. It is what the communication is doing.

I learned this distinction after discovering that members of a team I managed had created a private Slack channel. My first reaction mixed several concerns together: ordinary venting, the possibility that people did not trust the formal forums I had created, and the fear that the team's real decisions might be moving somewhere I could not see. Treating all three as “undermining” would have made a clean diagnosis impossible.

In a system where everyone holds some form of power, side conversations are inevitable. The manager's boundary is not private speech. It is the point at which a private network begins deciding, distorting information, or exercising authority without responsibility.

### Social backchanneling

“That meeting was exhausting.”

This is ordinary human behavior. People vent, bond, joke, and regulate emotion together. Managers should tolerate a great deal of it unless it becomes harassment, exclusion, discrimination, or sustained hostility that damages working relationships.

### Sensemaking backchanneling

“Does anyone understand why we're doing this?”

This may indicate that the formal explanation was unclear, the decision lacks credibility, or people do not feel safe asking questions publicly. The response is usually better communication and curiosity-not surveillance.

## Political backchanneling

“Don't raise this with the manager yet. Let's get everyone aligned and take it directly to the director.”

Here, the network is being used to alter decision-making power. Collective disagreement can be healthy; the concern is deliberate circumvention, information manipulation, or construction of a veto outside the agreed process.

## Shadow management

An employee begins assigning work without delegated authority, countermanding decisions, representing a personal view as team consensus, withholding information, establishing mandatory processes, making commitments for the team, or positioning themselves as the required intermediary between colleagues and management.

The employee has progressed into creating their own alternate operating structure.

## When to intervene

Employees with high degrees of informal influence can be some of the most healthy and effective contributors to team performance. However, intervention may be necessary when the the influence begins to interfere with the following:

1. **Decision rights:** The designated decision-maker can no longer make or implement the decision.
2. **Information integrity:** Relevant information is distorted, selectively withheld, or falsely presented as consensus.
3. **Accountability:** Someone exercises authority while responsibility for the consequences remains elsewhere.

Regulate conduct, not loyalty.

## 6. How the Manager–Employee Loop Escalates

One of the hardest patterns for me to recognize was the loop between a manager who felt threatened and an ambitious employee who felt blocked. Neither person had to choose open competition. Each could simply react to the other until the reactions became a system:

- The employee feels underused or excluded from meaningful influence.
- The employee builds influence informally or acts without approval.
- The manager experiences this as a threat to unsettled authority.
- The manager tightens control, adds approvals, or guards territory.
- The employee experiences tighter control as proof of gatekeeping.
- The employee relies more heavily on coalitions or unilateral action.
- The manager sees confirmation that the employee cannot be trusted.

The loop accelerates because each person experiences their own behavior as a reasonable response to the other.

This is one way “everyone is in charge” becomes a lived conflict rather than an abstract org-design problem. The manager has the title but feels unable to command the room. The employee lacks formal authority but may hold expertise, relationships, or enough peer support to frustrate implementation. Both respond by defending the kind of power available to them.

### Interrupting the loop

Examine three things simultaneously.

#### **The structure**

- Are decision rights genuinely clear?
- Has the employee been given responsibility without useful authority?
- Is the work stalled by unnecessary approvals?
- Are adjacent leaders competing over the same territory?

#### **The manager's reaction**

- Would the employee's idea still bother me if it were delivered calmly and privately?
- Am I protecting a governance boundary or defending my status?
- Am I requiring permission because risk demands it, or because involvement reassures me?

- Do I interpret another person's influence as a subtraction from my own?

The employee's conduct

- Did they raise the concern through an available channel?
- Are they acting beyond delegated scope?
- Are they accurately representing information and team opinion?
- Do they accept decisions they argued against?
- Does the same pattern persist after expectations and opportunities are clarified?

Self-reflection should improve diagnosis. It should not become an indefinite substitute for accountability.

## 7. Influence Is Not the Same as Authority

I learned that my title and another person's influence were not competing versions of the same thing. Formal authority came from my role. Their influence came from trust, expertise, relationships, credibility, communication skill, and access to information. The most influential person on a team may not manage anyone.

That is not necessarily a defect. Informal leaders can accelerate adoption, translate strategy, surface concerns, preserve institutional knowledge, mentor colleagues, and detect weak decisions early.

The useful question is:

Why do people trust this person, and how can that trust serve the team without becoming an unaccountable source of authority?

When everyone is in charge, the manager's job is not to make every form of influence flow through the manager. It is to connect influence to responsibility. The trusted IC should understand that shaping the room carries obligations: represent uncertainty honestly, avoid claiming consensus that has not been tested, and help the team act rather than making themselves indispensable to every decision.

## Manager script

“People trust your judgment, and that is valuable. I want to give that influence legitimate scope. I also need us to be explicit about the responsibility that comes with it: represent uncertainty honestly, do not speak for others without checking, and distinguish your recommendation from a final decision.”

The objective is to convert useful influence into accountable contribution-not suppress it or quietly turn the person into an unpaid manager.

## 8. Give Ambition Somewhere Useful to Go

Ambition is organizational energy. If people management is the only respected form of advancement, ambitious ICs will compete for scarce roles, manufacture managerial status informally, disengage, or leave.

Top-heavy organizations make this problem especially sharp. They may already contain more leadership titles than the work requires, yet still have talented people seeking growth. Adding another vague layer makes everyone more in charge and no one more accountable.

A healthier system offers increasing scope through subject-matter ownership, project leadership, process design, mentoring, cross-functional representation, stakeholder presentations, strategic recommendations, experiment ownership, or operational stewardship.

The crucial distinction is:

You can increase someone's influence, autonomy, and impact without giving them authority over other people.

### A bounded-territory assignment

“You've identified recurring problems in our returns content, and I agree that it needs stronger ownership. I'd like you to own that content area for the next quarter. You may revise articles within our standards, collect performance data, and coordinate input from the returns team. Policy changes and work assignments remain with me. We'll review accuracy, adoption, and case-resolution metrics after six weeks.”

## Use scope as a diagnostic

Giving an ambitious employee bounded territory is both a development opportunity and a diagnostic intervention. Observe whether the person improves the area, accepts constraints, invites expertise, communicates tradeoffs, finishes work, shares credit, distinguishes recommendations from decisions, and remains within agreed boundaries.

If behavior improves, blocked ambition or structural ambiguity was probably an important cause. If every assignment becomes a beachhead for acquiring neighboring authority, the problem is no longer adequately explained by lack of opportunity.

## Case study: ambition finds legitimate territory

A talented customer-experience employee wanted greater influence, but the organization's formal leadership positions were already filled. Early interactions between the employee and manager were messy and sometimes fraught. The employee occasionally worked outside the expected process, while the manager was still establishing authority within an unusually crowded leadership layer.

The eventual solution was not a fabricated management role. The employee developed deeper specialization in warranty work and technical troubleshooting. Because he understood both frontline customer experience and the warranty function, he could translate between the two areas in a way that few others could.

He ultimately became a warranty specialist and took over cross-training for the customer-experience team. His influence grew through expertise, training, and responsibility rather than through ambiguous authority over peers.

The outcome did not make every earlier interaction productive or erase the underlying conflict. It demonstrated something more useful: ambition that

initially contributed to territorial friction could become organizational infrastructure once it had meaningful territory and clear value.

For a manager, the diagnostic question is not merely whether an employee wants more power. It is whether the employee can convert defined scope into expertise, service, and accountable contribution.

## 9. Be Honest When There Is No Promotion Path

Sometimes there is no management opening and no reason to expect one. I learned that inventing a vague, almost-manager role does not solve that problem. It may preserve hope for a while, but it also creates another layer of unclear authority.

Fake hierarchy creates ambiguity: peers do not know whether the employee can direct them, the employee performs management work without formal authority or compensation, existing leaders acquire an unofficial competitor, and temporary assignments are interpreted as promises.

Offer scope, not counterfeit rank.

### Candid career script

“I believe you are capable of leadership, and I want to be transparent about the structure. We do not have a management opening, and I do not expect one in the near future. I can offer meaningful ownership, visibility, and opportunities to develop leadership skills, but I do not want to imply that those assignments guarantee a promotion here.”

If the employee decides they must leave to obtain the role they want, that is not automatically a management failure. Sometimes honest development helps someone reach the point where the organization can no longer accommodate their ambitions.

## 10. Address the Behavior

### Without Guessing the Motive

“Why are you undermining me?” asserts intent and turns a governance conversation into a contest over identity. Start with observable behavior, its impact, the relevant standard, and a question.

#### Core script

“I’ve noticed three situations in which you disagreed with a decision, did not raise the concern with me, and then tried to change the outcome through other people. I want disagreement on this team. I need it brought into the decision process rather than used to work around that process. What is making it difficult to raise these concerns directly?”

Curiosity leaves room for misunderstanding, conflicting instructions, urgency, a failed formal channel, or deliberate circumvention. It improves accuracy; it does not weaken the boundary.

#### When unilateral action produced a good result

“The result is useful, and I appreciate the initiative. The concern is that you committed team resources without authority to do so. Let’s separate the quality of the idea from the process used. Here is the scope you can act within independently next time.”

## When the pattern continues

“We have discussed the expectation, clarified your decision rights, and created a direct channel for disagreement. The same behavior has continued. This is now an accountability issue.”

Once the system is clear, dissent is safe, and expectations have been discussed, repeated violations should be managed as behavior-not endlessly reinterpreted as unmet potential.

# Conclusion: What I Would Do Differently

The title is a joke, but the problem was real: what do you do when the kitchen is full of people giving direction and nobody is sure whose meal is being made?

You begin by recognizing that “in charge” is not one thing. A manager may own the final decision while an IC owns the expertise required to make it intelligently. A team lead may control implementation while an informal leader shapes whether people trust the change. A senior specialist may have access to stakeholders the manager cannot reach. The problem is not that these people possess power. The problem is leaving their powers unbounded, unsupported, or disconnected from responsibility.

The mature leadership question is not:

“How do I make difficult employees respect my authority?”

It is:

“How do I build a team in which authority, dissent, ambition, and influence all have legitimate places to go?”

That system will not eliminate conflict. It will make conflict more interpretable.

My own thinking began with a much more personal question: how could I make a difficult employee respect my authority? That question kept me focused on winning the relationship. It treated authority as something another person had to validate and conflict as proof that one of us had failed.

The more useful question was: what conditions made our relationship take that shape, and what was still mine to change?

I can now see three things at once. I was an inexperienced manager establishing territory within a crowded leadership system. I was managing a talented and sometimes oppositional employee whose ambition had nowhere obvious to go. And the organization had not made power sufficiently legible for either of us. Change any one of those variables and the relationship might have unfolded differently.

That interpretation does not excuse every choice. It gives me a better sequence for responding next time: examine the structure, examine my own reaction, clarify legitimate scope, and then hold the behavioral boundary.

It also helps me understand later roles in which I was expected to influence outcomes without owning the machinery required to produce them. I was not always failing to find my lane. Sometimes the organization had never constructed one.

Clear authority prevents ordinary disagreement from becoming a succession struggle. Safe dissent allows opposition to surface before it turns covert. Legitimate scope converts ambition into contribution. Responsible influence turns trusted employees into infrastructure rather than alternate management. Coherent roles connect judgment and responsibility to an actual ability to act.

People do not necessarily need control over everything. They do need a legible relationship among their judgment, responsibility, authority, ability to act, and accountability for the result.

When that relationship is missing, they may become territorial, argumentative, hesitant, disengaged, or excessively dependent on persuasion. Those reactions still deserve reflection and, where necessary, correction. But they occur under a real structural strain.

A manager should therefore ask not only:

“Why is this person struggling to stay in their lane?”

But also:

“Did the organization ever construct a lane they could recognize, occupy, and succeed within?”

And when someone still manipulates information, circumvents decisions, or exercises authority without accountability after fair channels have been supplied, the manager can intervene with confidence. The remaining issue is behavior.

The aim is neither total managerial control nor endless accommodation. It is a team in which many people can exercise real power without pretending they possess the same authority. People can gain scope by accepting responsibility, challenge decisions without sabotaging them, own meaningful work without conquering territory, and understand exactly where their authority begins and ends.

Authority needs boundaries. Dissent needs safety. Ambition needs pathways. Influence needs responsibility.

That is how a manager leads when everyone is in charge: not by reclaiming every decision, but by making power visible, useful, and accountable before its shadow version takes over.